

RANJAN RAHI

Reena Kumari, *45*

Lohagir, Bihar

Former village mukhiya

Constituency: Ujiarpur

Issues that will decide her vote: Inflation, unemployment, poor returns in farming

Demands from the govt: Create jobs, curb inflation, ensure religious harmony

"If there are sufficient jobs, educated youth will be able to contribute positively to our society and the country"

ing his father in the dairy business, while the younger, 19, is studying. She wants both of them to find government jobs. "You can see educated youth," says Reena, "becoming disillusioned because they lack employment opportunities."

When it comes to her voting decision, Reena emphasises that her entire family sits together to discuss the available choices and collectively decide on a candidate. In a state where caste plays a key role in deciding the vote, she, a Yadav, asserts, "caste is not the determining factor" in the case of their family. ■

–Amitabh Srivastava

A Widow's Lament

Lata Ganesh Suryavanshi, *58*

Pune, *Does stitching from home*

Constituency: Pune

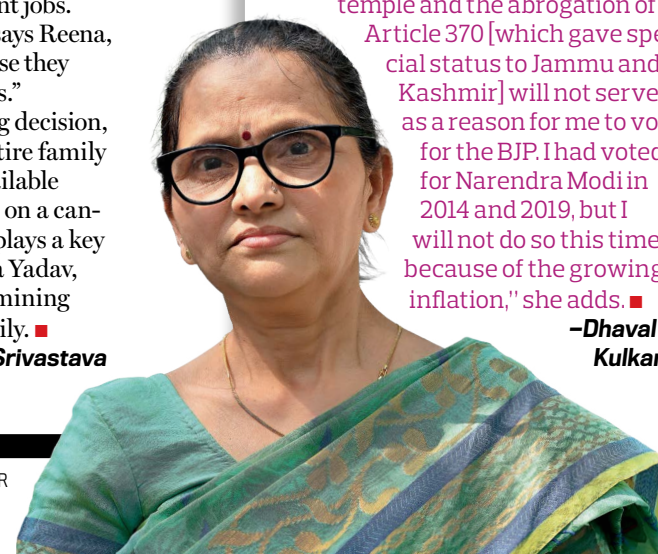
Issues that will decide her vote: Inflation

Demands from the government: Reduction in inflation, LPG prices and power tariffs, support for weaker sections of society, such as widows

It has been 18 years since Suryavanshi's husband passed away, and the childless widow who has studied till class X, takes on stitching jobs at home to make a living. "The prices of LPG cylinders have soared; I have no option but to use them, though I can ill afford it. The cost of essentials is also rising and electricity tariffs and GST are pinching the common man. Unfortunately, I have no aid from anyone to fall back on," she says.

Suryavanshi says her vote will go to the Congress, as she feels they can rectify these issues. "I want to go to the Ram Mandir at Ayodhya and also to Kashi. But issues like the Ram temple and the abrogation of Article 370 [which gave special status to Jammu and Kashmir] will not serve as a reason for me to vote for the BJP. I had voted for Narendra Modi in 2014 and 2019, but I will not do so this time because of the growing inflation," she adds. ■

–Dhaval S. Kulkarni



MANDAR DEODHAR